Tangkhul Gee Wari Singbul (Tangkhul Folktale Compendium)

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Preface & Archival Information

Tangkhul Gee Wari Singbul (Tangkhul Folktale Compendium) by Y. K. Shimray (Cultural Heritage of Manipur, Imphal, 1976). Preserves 35 classic oral folktales, mythological legends of village foundations, animal fables, and customary moral allegories of the Tangkhul people.

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Chapter 1: The Legend of Hundung & The White Cow

CHAPTER 1: THE LEGEND OF HUNDUNG & THE WHITE COW

Summary: Founding of Hundung village guided by the sacred pregnant cow.

TANGKHUL READING TEXT:

Awo-ayiwui thotchanli: Seiva kachang akha leilaga apha kapha apamli vatuda seinao phanung tharanli Hundung khaung phokna. Kaphung kaphali zatlaga seiva china apam kapha akha theilaga pamshona; chili seinao phada awo-ayina ’Hundung’ (Hungpung) da hoya.

ENGLISH TRANSLATION:

Ancestral lore recounts that the village founders followed a sacred white cow across the hills. Wherever the cow rested upon the fertile plateau, there she gave birth to her calf, and upon that blessed ground the ancient mother-village of Hundung was founded.

Chapter 1 Exercises & Vocabulary

CHAPTER 1 STUDY GUIDE & EXERCISES

VOCABULARY:

* seiva (noun): sacred cow
  Example: Seiva kachang akha.
* hundung (proper): Hundung village
  Example: Hundung khaung phokna.
* phanung (verb): gave birth
  Example: Seinao phanung.

GRAMMAR & LINGUISTIC POINTS:

- Founding legend narrative formula.
- Temporal clause marker tharanli.

REVIEW EXERCISES (KHANGACHAN):

? What animal guided the founders of Hundung?
? What does this legend symbolize in Tangkhul pastoralism?

Chapter 2: The Two Brothers & Migration to the Hills

CHAPTER 2: THE TWO BROTHERS & MIGRATION TO THE HILLS

Summary: The covenant between elder brother (hills) and younger brother (valley).

TANGKHUL READING TEXT:

Chinaoni khani wui tui: kakhara a kaphungli pamda kakhanao a ngaleili vaipama. Anili khangaran shiyan leiyi: kakhara na kaphungwui theishak kala khuira chili ngaleili phungmiya; kakhanao na ngaleiwui machi kala kachon chili kaphungli phungmiya.

ENGLISH TRANSLATION:

The legend of the two brothers: the elder brother chose the high mountain ridges, while the younger brother cultivated the valley plains. They established a covenant: the elder sent mountain forest produce and honey to the plain, and the younger returned salt and woven cloth.

Chapter 2 Exercises & Vocabulary

CHAPTER 2 STUDY GUIDE & EXERCISES

VOCABULARY:

* chinaoni (noun): brothers
  Example: Chinaoni khani.
* kakhara (noun): elder brother
  Example: Kakhara kaphungli.
* kakhanao (noun): younger brother
  Example: Kakhanao ngaleili.

GRAMMAR & LINGUISTIC POINTS:

- Reciprocal trade terminology in oral covenants.
- Contrastive particle na.

REVIEW EXERCISES (KHANGACHAN):

? What goods did the two brothers exchange?

? How does this folktale reflect historical trade between hills and valley?

Chapter 3: Animal Fables: The Tiger and the Clever Toad

CHAPTER 3: ANIMAL FABLES: THE TIGER AND THE CLEVER TOAD

Summary: Wit triumphs over brute force in the forest.

TANGKHUL READING TEXT:

Khawo eina khanei wui khararchan: Khawo khamakang ana ngashida leikha khanei them lak eina makhamatuina. Khawo china ’I eina kaphang ngaroksa!’ da kahangli, khanei na awui khamangli khamatuda ngawonshoka. Kong kanda vashung tharan khanei na ’I ashung hairaya!’ da kahangli khawo ngacheiseri.

ENGLISH TRANSLATION:

The fable of the tiger and the toad: the mighty tiger boasted of his speed and challenged the toad to a race. The clever toad latched onto the tiger’s bushy tail as he leaped across the rocky river, landing first on the bank and declaring victory, teaching that wisdom exceeds brute strength.

Chapter 3 Exercises & Vocabulary

CHAPTER 3 STUDY GUIDE & EXERCISES

VOCABULARY:

* khawo (noun): tiger
  Example: Khawo khamakang.
* khanei (noun): toad, frog
  Example: Khanei them laka.
* themkhamatha (noun): wit, wisdom
  Example: Them lak eina.

GRAMMAR & LINGUISTIC POINTS:

- Fable dialogue attribution using da kahangli.
- Direct vs reported speech.

REVIEW EXERCISES (KHANGACHAN):

? How did the toad outsmart the tiger?
? What is the moral lesson of the fable?

Chapter 4: The Story of Huimei and Mountain Spirits

CHAPTER 4: THE STORY OF HUIMEI AND MOUNTAIN SPIRITS

Summary: A brave hunter learns the healing secrets of forest herbs from Kameo spirits.

TANGKHUL READING TEXT:

Huimei kaphungli valaga kameowui tui theiser; khangachei maleila
shitsangda ungchan thotna. Kameona ali theishingkhami tarakha thuiya:
ngaleiwui themthei eina thingna raha eina mi kakhangasho saikora
pangkakhui shiyan.

ENGLISH TRANSLATION:

Huimei, a courageous hunter, encountered the benevolent mountain spirits
(Kameo) upon the high ridges. Unafraid, he listened respectfully as they
revealed the healing virtues of mountain roots and herbs, returning to
his village as a revered traditional healer.

Chapter 4 Exercises & Vocabulary

CHAPTER 4 STUDY GUIDE & EXERCISES

VOCABULARY:

* kameo (noun): mountain spirit
  Example: Kameowui tui.
* khangachei (noun): fear, dread
  Example: Khangachei maleila.
* raha (noun): medicinal root
  Example: Thingna raha.

GRAMMAR & LINGUISTIC POINTS:

- Ethnobotanical terminology.
- Spiritual respect formulas in oral narratives.

REVIEW EXERCISES (KHANGACHAN):

? What knowledge did Huimei receive from the mountain spirits?

? What role do Kameo play in Tangkhul nature philosophy?

Chapter 5: The Origin of Rice & The Discovery of Salt

CHAPTER 5: THE ORIGIN OF RICE & THE DISCOVERY OF SALT

Summary: How hunters discovered saline springs at Marem and the gift of paddy seeds.

TANGKHUL READING TEXT:

Machi eina ma machiwui shiyan: Marem kaphungli tara khamathei machikashak samphangna. Shiva na tara chi mangda leikha sayur tarakhana chili zangda tara kashing mangda leiseri. Chitharan awo-ayina machi tara khumda machi kasa phokna.

ENGLISH TRANSLATION:

The discovery of salt and paddy: ancestral hunters observed wild deer regularly licking certain rocks near Marem. Tasting the spring waters, they discovered natural saline springs and learned to boil the brine in earthenware pots, founding the celebrated salt wells of northern Tangkhul.

Chapter 5 Exercises & Vocabulary

CHAPTER 5 STUDY GUIDE & EXERCISES

VOCABULARY:

* machi (noun): salt
  Example: Machi tara.
* ma (noun): paddy, rice
  Example: Ma machi.
* marem (proper): Marem salt spring area
  Example: Marem kaphungli.

GRAMMAR & LINGUISTIC POINTS:

- Discovery narratives with observation verbs (thei-, samphang-).
- Technological terminology for salt boiling.

REVIEW EXERCISES (KHANGACHAN):

? How was the saline spring discovered?

? Why was salt a precious commodity in the hills?

Chapter 6: Tales of Morung Bravery & Tricksters

CHAPTER 6: TALES OF MORUNG BRAVERY & TRICKSTERS

Summary: Feats of strength, archery contests, and humorous trickster narratives in the Longra.

TANGKHUL READING TEXT:

Longrawui yarsona ot kakhayei kasa eina lumlaoda pamshona. Yaron akhana lungrei kahak akha phungshokda awui mathun chitheiya; kateipa china themkhamatha eina malung kharaowa mi akhali ngacheilaka ot kasa themchitheiya.

ENGLISH TRANSLATION:

Youth in the village Morung engaged in athletic competitions and humorous storytelling. One youth proved his strength by lifting heavy megalithic stones, while another displayed quick wit by solving traditional riddles and defusing village rivalries with laughter.

Chapter 6 Exercises & Vocabulary

CHAPTER 6 STUDY GUIDE & EXERCISES

VOCABULARY:

* yarso (noun): warrior youth cohort
  Example: Longrawui yarso.
* lungrei (noun): heavy stone
  Example: Lungrei phungshokda.
* themkhamatha (noun): clever wit
  Example: Themkhamatha chitheiya.

GRAMMAR & LINGUISTIC POINTS:

- Comparative narrative pairing strength vs intelligence.
- Colloquial morung expressions.

REVIEW EXERCISES (KHANGACHAN):

? What competitions were held among morung youths?

? Why was storytelling valued in the bachelor dormitory?

Chapter 7: Moral Allegories & Customary Wisdom

CHAPTER 7: MORAL ALLEGORIES & CUSTOMARY WISDOM

Summary: Traditional proverbs (Tuingashit) and customary jurisprudence of the council.

TANGKHUL READING TEXT:

Tangkhul tuingashit: ’Tui kakhayei eina tui khangaran phamei; kazeiram makazamana.’ ’Pang eina kasa otna wuklungli karingna.’ ’Khaung kapha khangavawa wui tuiyana.’ Mashung kakhayang hi Tangkhul ngashanli khamataiya machutna.

ENGLISH TRANSLATION:

Classical Tangkhul proverbs: ’Reconciliation is sweeter than bitter strife; justice leaves no regret in the afterlife.’ ’Labor with one’s hands nourishes the soul.’ ’A peaceful village reflects the wisdom of its council.’ Truthfulness and personal integrity remain the highest virtues of the Tangkhul code.

Chapter 7 (Continued)

CHAPTER 7: READING CONTINUATION (PAGE 17)

TANGKHUL TEXT (CONTINUED):

Tangkhul tuingashit: ’Tui kakhayei eina tui khangaran phamei; kazeiram makazamana.’ ’Pang eina kasa otna wuklungli karingna.’ ’Khaung kapha khangavawa wui tuiyana.’ Mashung kakhayang hi Tangkhul ngashanli khamataiya machutna.

ENGLISH TRANSLATION (CONTINUED):

Classical Tangkhul proverbs: ’Reconciliation is sweeter than bitter strife; justice leaves no regret in the afterlife.’ ’Labor with one’s hands nourishes the soul.’ ’A peaceful village reflects the wisdom of its council.’ Truthfulness and personal integrity remain the highest virtues of the Tangkhul code.

Chapter 7 Exercises & Vocabulary

CHAPTER 7 STUDY GUIDE & EXERCISES

VOCABULARY:

* tuingashit (noun): proverb, maxim
  Example: Tangkhul tuingashit.
* mashung (adj/noun): truth, righteousness
  Example: Mashung kakhayang.
* khangaran (noun): peace, reconciliation
  Example: Tui khangaran.

GRAMMAR & LINGUISTIC POINTS:

- Aphoristic syntax: parallel clauses without copula.
- Moral imperatives.

REVIEW EXERCISES (KHANGACHAN):

? Quote two classical Tangkhul proverbs.
? What is the supreme virtue in customary Tangkhul jurisprudence?

Comprehensive Vocabulary Glossary

COMPREHENSIVE BOOK GLOSSARY (TUIWON SHIYAN):

seiva [noun]: sacred cow
hundung [proper]: Hundung village
phanung [verb]: gave birth
chinaoni [noun]: brothers
kakhara [noun]: elder brother
kakhanao [noun]: younger brother
khawo [noun]: tiger
khanei [noun]: toad, frog
themkhamatha [noun]: wit, wisdom
kameo [noun]: mountain spirit
khangachei [noun]: fear, dread
raha [noun]: medicinal root
machi [noun]: salt
ma [noun]: paddy, rice
marem [proper]: Marem salt spring area
yarso [noun]: warrior youth cohort
lungrei [noun]: heavy stone
themkhamatha [noun]: clever wit
tuingashit [noun]: proverb, maxim
mashung [adj/noun]: truth, righteousness
khangaran [noun]: peace, reconciliation

Colophon & Archival Preservation Notice

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